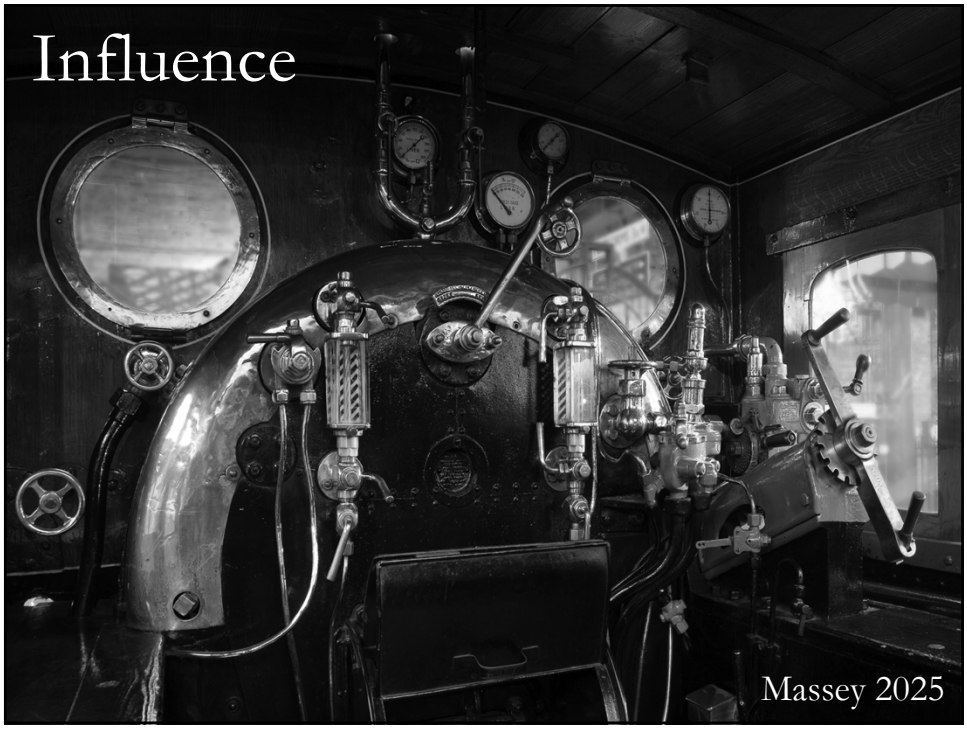


Course Admin

Next Class: Leverage Inventory debrief

- Survey due 8am the morning of class
- Reading: "Lincoln and the Tools of Influence"
- 2 short video lectures

Application #2

- Due by 8am Monday

Leverage Inventory

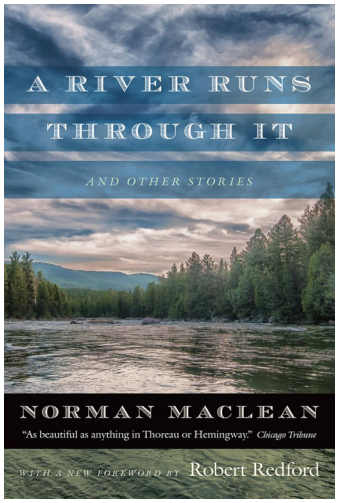
- Evaluator assessments due tomorrow
- Self-assessment due tomorrow

"Triple Helix" exercise

- Results due 1pm Tuesday

"Half as long"





https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7vRhOdf-6co

My own application

Remember this reading from Class 6?



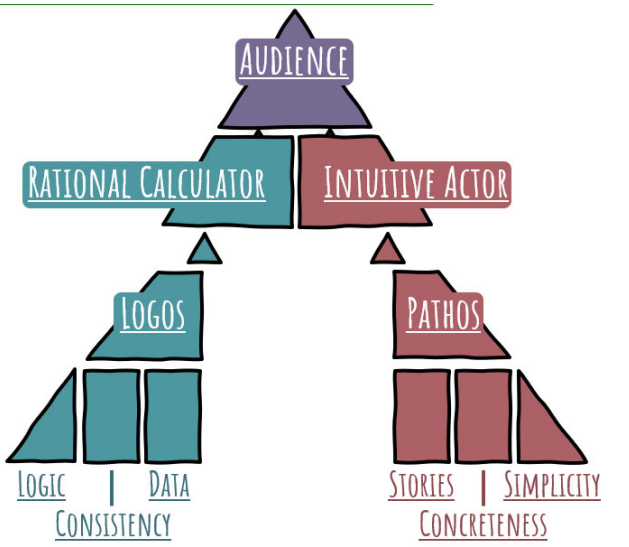
Today's Agenda

Ethos

Video assessment / Warmth & Competence

Lipman videos

Solving the Persuasion Puzzle





Ethos

You are persuasive, or not, before you've said a word.

- Who you are
- What you've done
- How you carry yourself

Your credentials speak for you before you open your mouth. And character continues while you to talk!

Ethos

Difficult, multi-dimensional construct

- No direct translation from the Greek

Facets

- Character
- Objectivity
- Similarity
- Credentials

In short: Why should the audience trust you?

Character

Journal of Personality and Social Psychology
2014, Vol. 106, No. 1, 148–168

© 2013 American Psychological Association
0022-3514/14/$12.00 DOI: 10.1037/a0034726

Moral Character Predominates in Person Perception and Evaluation

Geoffrey P. Goodwin, Jared Piazza, and Paul Rozin
University of Pennsylvania

What sorts of trait information do people most care about when forming impressions of others? Recent research in social cognition suggests that "warmth," broadly construed, should be of prime importance in impression formation. Yet, some prior research suggests that information about others' specifically moral traits—their moral "character"—may be a primary dimension. Although warmth and character have sometimes been conceived of as interchangeable, we argue that they are separable, and that across a wide variety of contexts, character is usually more important than warmth in impression formation. We first showed that moral character and social warmth traits are indeed separable (Studies 1 and 2). Further studies that used correlational and experimental methods showed that, as predicted, in most contexts, moral character information is more important in impression formation than is warmth information (Studies 2–6). Character information was also more important than warmth information with respect to judgments of traits' perceived fundamentalness to identity, their uniquely human quality, their context-independence, and their controllability (Study 2). Finally, Study 7 used an archival method to show that moral character information appears more prominently than warmth information in obituaries, and more strongly determines the impressions people form of the individuals described in those obituaries. We discuss implications for current theories of person perception and social cognition.

Keywords: moral character, warmth, sociability, person perception, global impressions

When you choose your friends, don't be short-changed by choosing personality over character.

—W. Somerset Maugham

especially in relation to moral choice" (Kupperman, 1991, p. 13). In a nutshell, moral character comprises the moral dimensions of a person's personality.

Objectivity



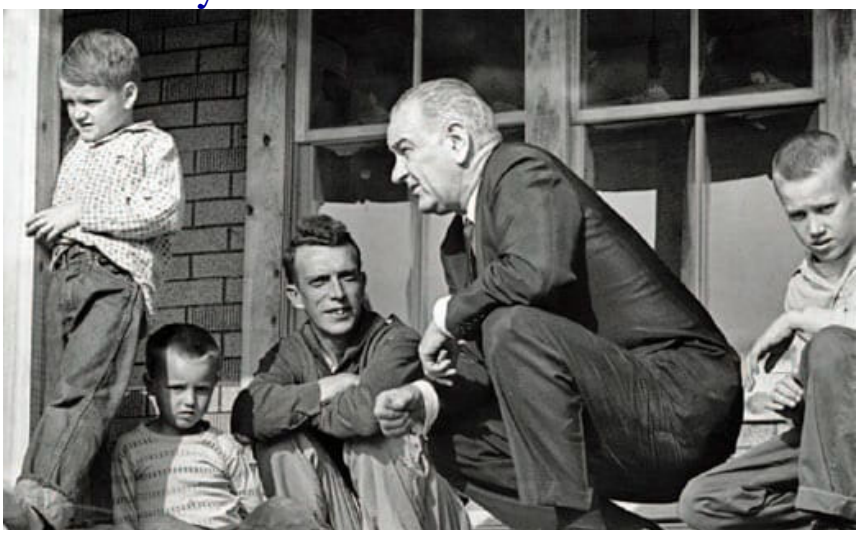
Prescriptions from Moussa & Shell

Ben Franklin, at Constitutional Convention

"It is with reluctance that I rise to express a disapprobation of any one article of the plan, for which we are so much obliged to the honorable gentlemen who laid it before us. From its first reading, I have borne a good will to it, and, in general, wished it success. In this particular of salaries to the executive branch, I happen to differ; and, as my opinion my appear new and chimerical, it is only from a persuasion that it is right, and from a sense of duty, that I hazard it. The Committee will judge of my reasons when they have heard them, and their judgment may possibly change mine."

(in Corbett & Connors, 1999)

Similarity



"You persuade a man only insofar as you can talk his language by speech, gesture, tonality, order, image, attitude, idea, identifying your ways with his."

- Kenneth Burke, American poet (and rhetorical theorist)

But: "Optimal Differentiation"

If you're **similar** on all dimensions what value do you add?

- Remember CC: "In order to be invaluable you have to be different"

If you're **different** on all dimensions it's tough to get traction

Most influential is some blend of similarities and differences

=> You don't have to share all dimensions, but you need to share some.

Credentials

People will find you more persuasive if they know your credentials…

…but mostly don't want to hear about your credentials!

=> The "Self-Promotion Dilemma"



The New York Times
BestSellers Print Hardcover

THIS WEEK	LAST WEEK	Nonfiction	WEEKS ON LIST
1	1	**UNTAMED,** by Glennon Doyle. (Dial) The activist and public speaker describes her journey of listening to her inner voice.	12
2	3	**PLAGUE OF CORRUPTION,** by Judy Mikovits and Kent Heckenlively. (Skyhorse) The controversial virologist gives her account of her work over nearly four decades.	4
3	2	**BECOMING,** by Michelle Obama. (Crown) The former first lady describes how she balanced work, family and her husband's political ascent.	77
4	4	**THE SPLENDID AND THE VILE,** by Erik Larson. (Crown) An examination of the leadership of the prime minister Winston Churchill.	14
5		**HOW TO BE AN ANTIRACIST,** by Ibram X. Kendi. (One World) A primer for creating a more just and equitable society through identifying and opposing racism.	13
6		[redacted]	1
7	5	**EDUCATED,** by Tara Westover. (Random House) The daughter of survivalists, who is kept out of school, educates herself enough to leave home for university.	119
8		**HOLLYWOOD PARK,** by Mikel Jollett. (Celadon) The musician and author retraces his time growing up in an experimental commune and the difficulties he encountered after escaping it.	1
9	8	**AMERICAN CRUSADE,** by Pete Hegseth. (Center Street) The "Fox & Friends Weekend" host gives his take on politics, culture and education. (†)	2
10		**ME AND WHITE SUPREMACY,** by Layla F. Saad. (Sourcebooks) Ways to understand and possibly counteract white privilege.	2

Rx for "The Self-Promotion Dilemma"

A simple start: Just don't overdo the self-deprecation

"Hype man" or "Hype woman"

- Role of introductions

In context vs. Out of context

- Modulate for the situation – dial up and down



Can we have professional authority and personal humility?



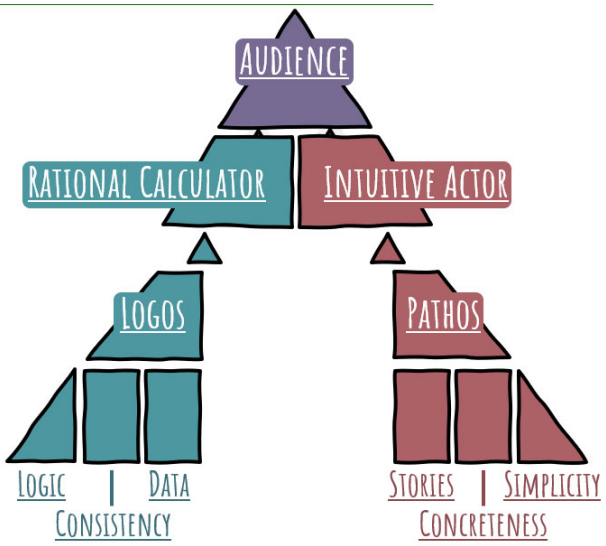
Recapping Ethos

Facets:

- Character
- Objectivity
- Similarity
- Character

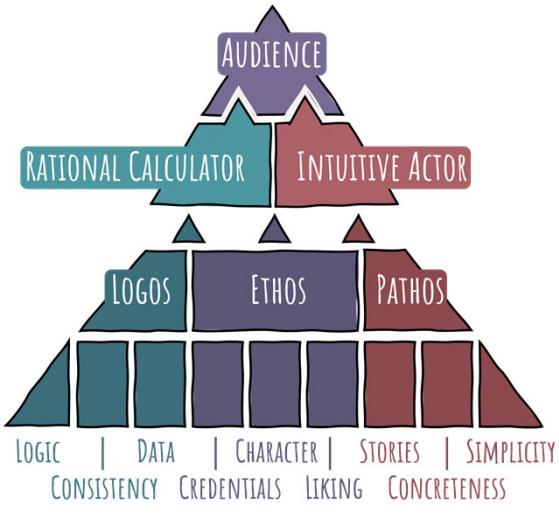
In short: Why should the audience trust you?

Solving the Persuasion Puzzle



@dstildco

Solving the Persuasion Puzzle



Today's Agenda

Ethos

Video assessment / Warmth & Competence

Lipman videos



VITA assessment

First impressions
Public speaking
Person perception, in general

Persuasive Video reports out this week

Evaluator ratings:

- Warmth, Competence, Integrity
  - Note: Integrity ratings not very reliable in this setting

Algorithm ratings (trained on experts):

- Filler words, facial expressions, word choice, etc.

There is signal here, but it is noisy

- You need to integrate it with other feedback

Warmth-Competence

From Princeton psychologist Susan Fiske and colleagues

"Universal dimensions of social cognition"

- Claim: These are the fundamental dimensions on which we perceive others.

Warmth

- E.g., trustworthy, friendly, honest, likeable, sincere

Competence

- E.g, intelligent, assertive, skilled efficient, confident

Part of the "Big 2" in psychology

The most fundamental framework for organizing motivation, personality and perception

Warmth/Community

- Sociability
- Morality

Competence/Agency

- Skills
- Assertiveness

Nuances

Warmth is preeminent

- Perceived first
- People get spread out more on this dimension

Compensation effect

- Especially when reasoning about groups, or about individuals from a distance (so use group membership):
  - Tend to believe high competence implies low warmth…
  - …And high warmth implies low competence

Hierarchy effects

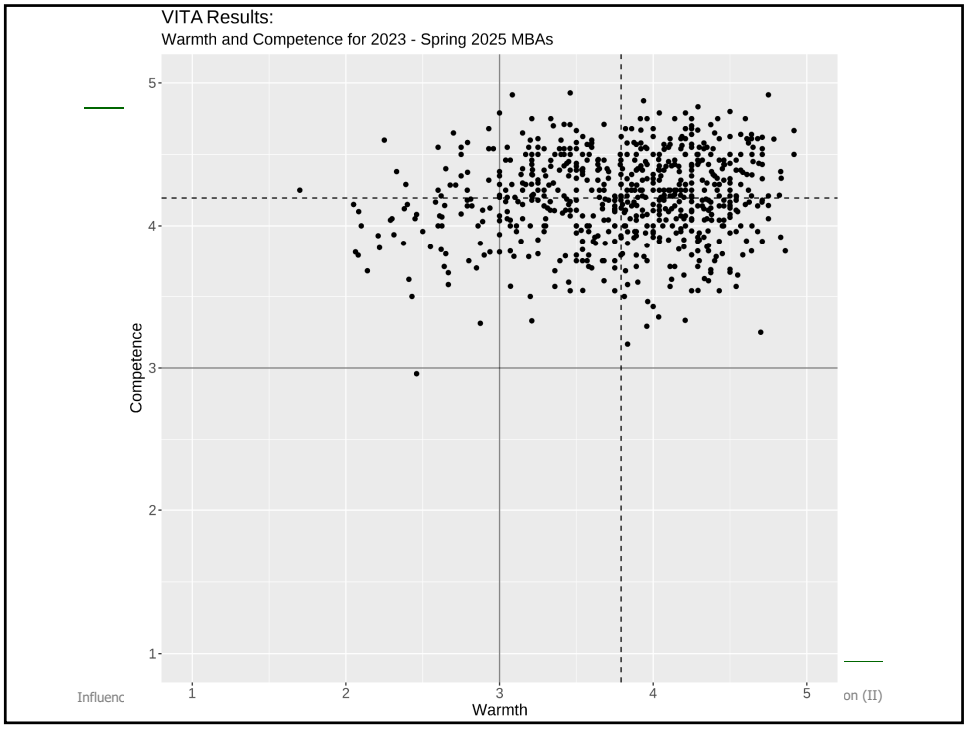
- We attend more to warmth when perceiving superiors (because we assume competence)…
- …and attend more to competence when perceiving subordinates (because we assume warmth)

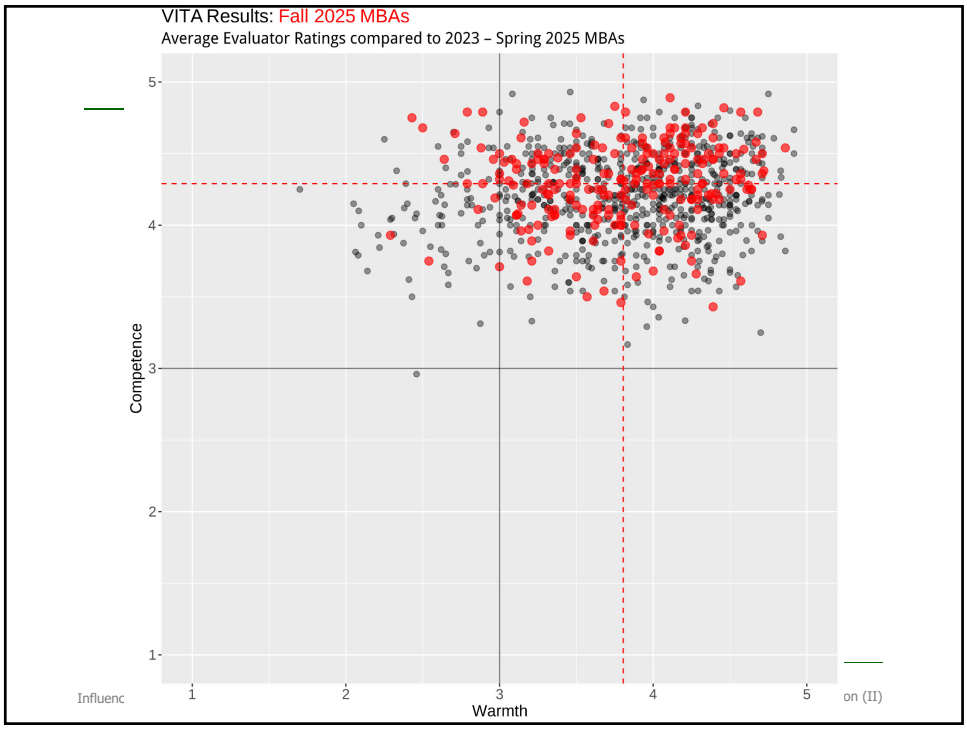
Your assessment

An evaluation by a small group of classmates of a short video introduction you made.

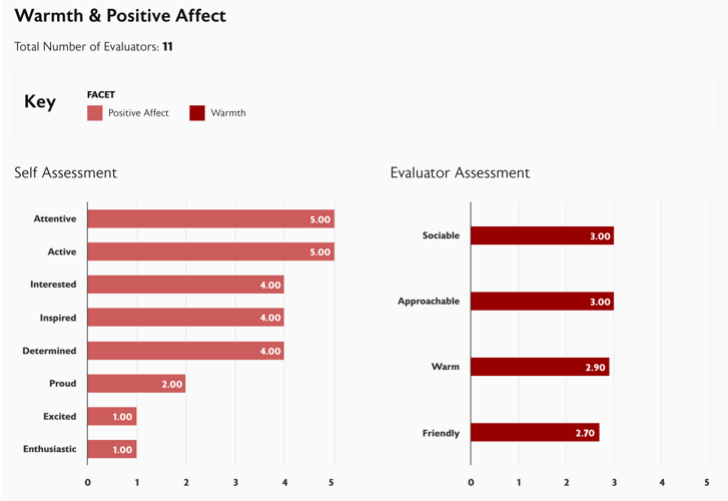
- Pros
  - Relevant group
  - Professional introductions are ubiquitous
  - Digital communication is common
- Cons
  - They already know you (so not "clean")
  - How hard did you try with your video?
  - "Only" an introduction

+ some algorithmic evaluations of your specific speaking behaviors..

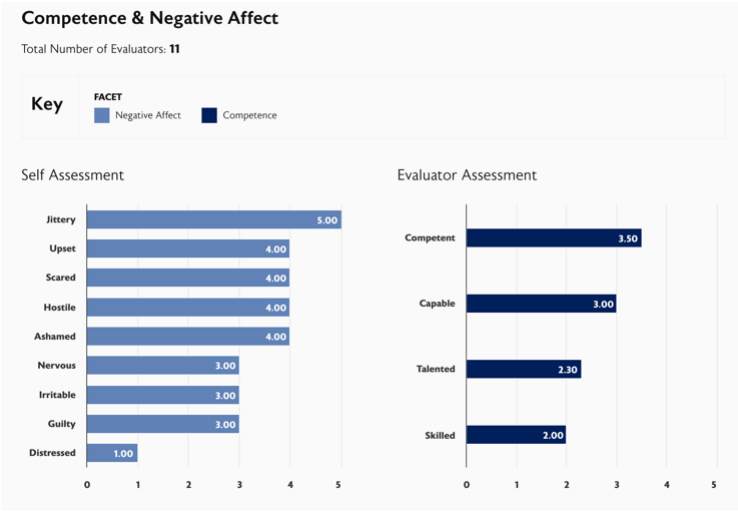

VITA Results:
Warmth and Competence for 2023 - Spring 2025 MBAs
Competence
Warmth
Influenc
on (II)

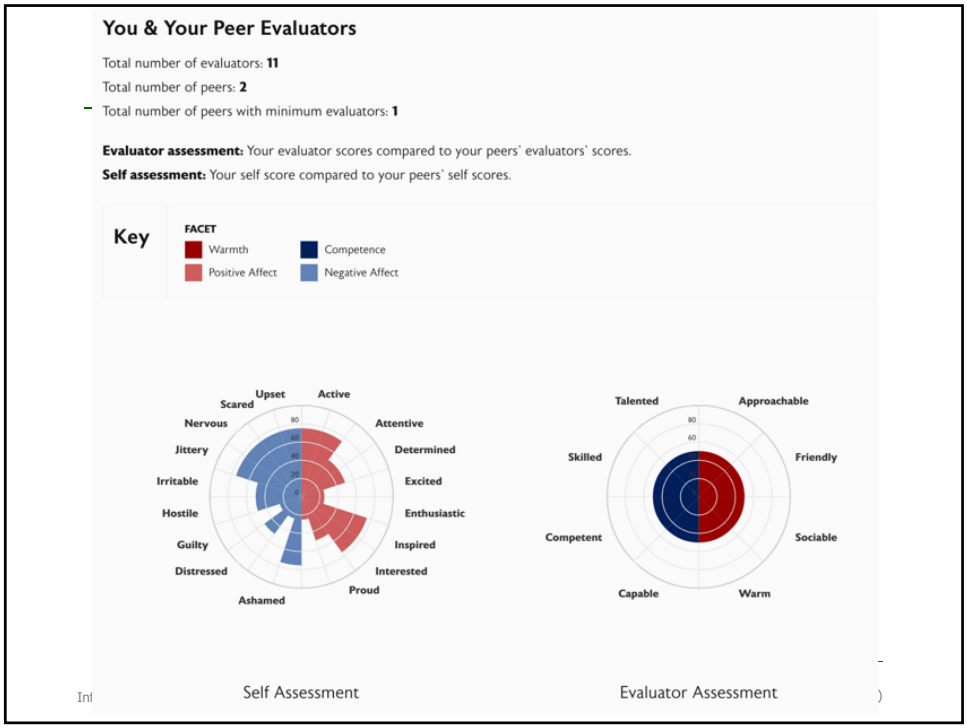

VITA Results: Fall 2025 MBAs
Average Evaluator Ratings compared to 2023 – Spring 2025 MBAs
Competence
Warmth
Influenc
on (II)

VITA report



VITA report





Speaking behaviors

Worked with Wharton's Communication group to quantify class public speaking behavior.

Experts rated ~500 videos.

Then we trained a machine learning model on those ratings.

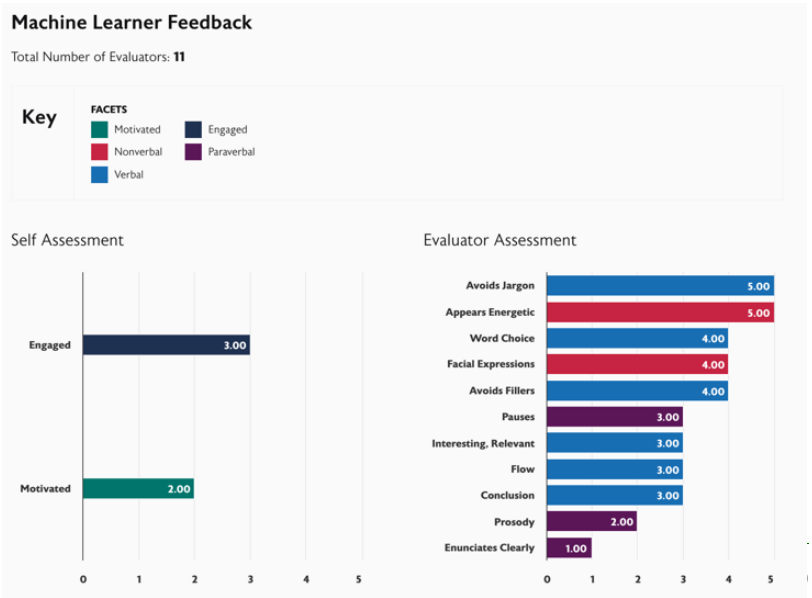
Public Speaking Behavioral Rubric (1 of 2)

		Ineffective	Somewhat Effective	Effective	Very Effective
Structure/Content	Ideas flow logically with clear transitions between main ideas	The content **lacks organization**	The content is **organized somewhat** logically.	The content is **mostly organized** logically	The content is **very organized** in such a way that is especially effective and logical
	Conclusion reinforces key message	The ending of the talk **fails to reinforce** its main ideas	The ending of the talk **summarizes** some of the main ideas.	The ending of the talk **reinforces** the main ideas	The conclusion **unites the main ideas** of the talk and is especially memorable, with a satisfying sense of completion
	Presentation is interesting and relevant to the audience	The content of this talk would **not captivate** its intended audience	The content of this talk has **little chance of captivating** its intended audience.	The content of this talk has a **good chance of captivating** its intended audience	The content of this talk would **likely captivate** its intended audience
Delivery: *Speaker…*	Uses audience-appropriate language and avoids jargon	Uses jargon, terms, etc. that makes this talk **hard to understand**	Sometimes uses jargon, terms, etc. that makes this talk **less clear and understandable** than it would otherwise be.	Mostly uses terms that are **clear and understandable**	Uses words that are **especially clear and understandable**
	Uses vivid and compelling word choices	Uses language that is **overly abstract** or **otherwise uninteresting**	Uses language that is **somewhat interesting** and **concrete**	Uses language that is **mostly interesting** and **concrete**	Uses especially **vivid and charismatic language**
	Uses few non-words/fillers	Vocal fillers ("um", "ya know", "like") are **frequent and distracting**	Vocal fillers ("um", "ya know", "like") are **somewhat frequent** and **detract**	Vocal fillers ("um", "ya know", "like") occur **occasionally** and **detract**	Vocal fillers ("um", "ya know", "like") **are infrequent** and **do not detract** from

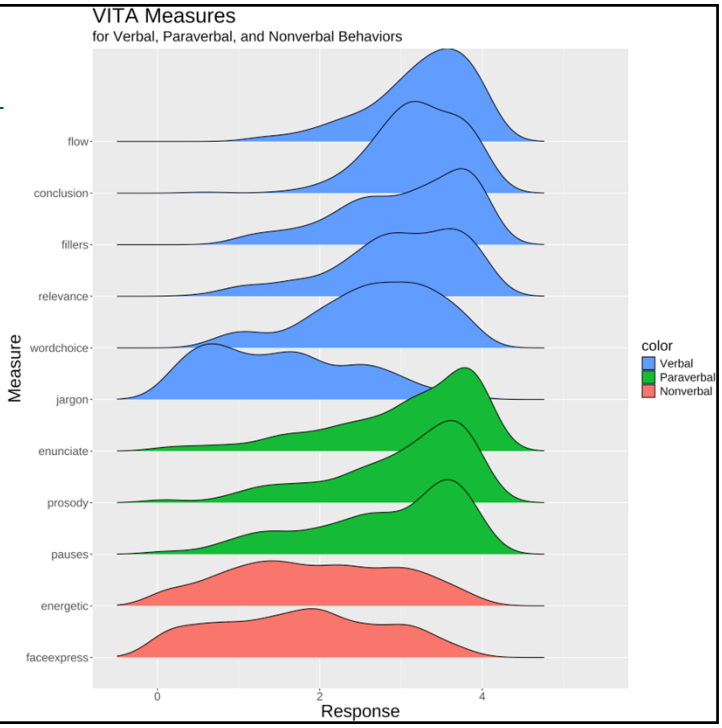
Public Speaking Behavioral Rubric (2 of 2)

			somewhat from impact of this talk	**minimally** from the impact of this talk.	the impact of this talk
	Enunciates clearly	**Fails** to enunciate clearly	**Occasionally** enunciates words clearly	**Usually** enunciates words clearly	Enunciates words **very clearly** throughout talk
	Uses vocal pace, volume, and pitch for emphasis and engagement	Delivery is **too fast, too slow, too loud, too soft, or lacks variation**	**Minor problems** with delivery in terms of pace, volume, or pitch	Delivery is **generally effective** in terms of pace, volume, and pitch	Delivery is **extremely effective** in terms of pace, volume, and pitch
	Incorporates pauses to enhance impact and clarity	Pauses are often **halting, abrupt, too lengthy, or completely absent**	Pauses are sometimes **halting, abrupt, or too lengthy**	Pauses are **appropriate**	**Strategic use** of pauses **heightens impact** of talk
	Establishes eye contact	**Limited** eye contact with the camera	**Occasional** eye contact with the camera	**Frequent** eye contact with the camera	**Sustained** eye contact with camera
	Uses notes appropriately (minimal reliance on notes)	**Depends heavily** on notes	References notes **occasionally**	References notes **rarely**	Has **no obvious dependence** on notes
	Uses animated facial expressions	**Never** displays animated facial expressions	**Rarely** displays animated facial expressions	**Occasionally** displays animated facial expressions	**Frequently** uses animated facial expressions
	Uses hand gestures	**Never** uses (hand) gestures	**Rarely** uses (hand) gestures	**Occasionally** uses (hand) gestures	**Frequently** uses (hand) gestures
	Is energetic	**Never** appears energetic	**Rarely** appears energetic	**Occasionally** appears energetic	**Frequently** appears energetic

VITA report



MBA Fall 2025:



Influence, Massey, Fall 2025

Speaking behaviors ~ Warmth/Competence

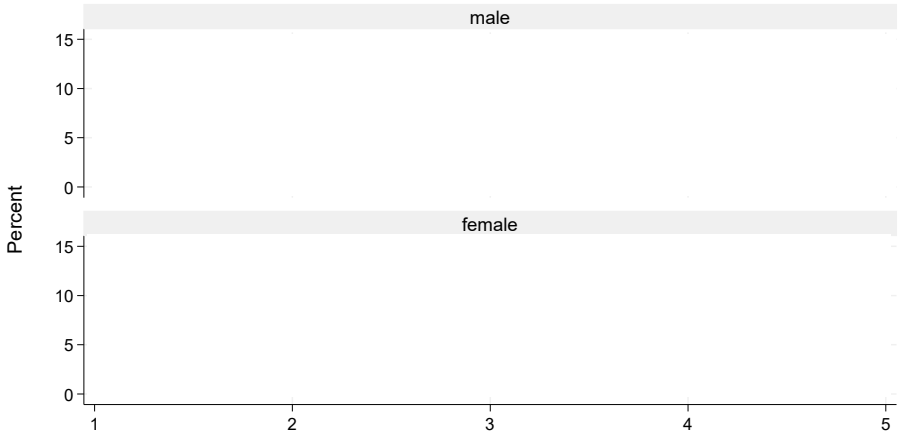
Correlations

MBAs, April 2024

Category	Behavior	Warmth	Competence
Verbal	Flow	.19	.56
Verbal	Avoids Fillers	.08	.41
Verbal	Conclusion	.01	.46
Verbal	Relevance	.37	.61
Verbal	Word Choice	.43	.50
Verbal	Jargon	.43	.09
Paraverbal	Pauses	.40	.55
Paraverbal	Prosody	.47	.54
Paraverbal	Enunciate	.43	.39
Nonverbal	Energetic	.75	.17
Nonverbal	Facial expressions	.80	.32

Average Warmth Rating

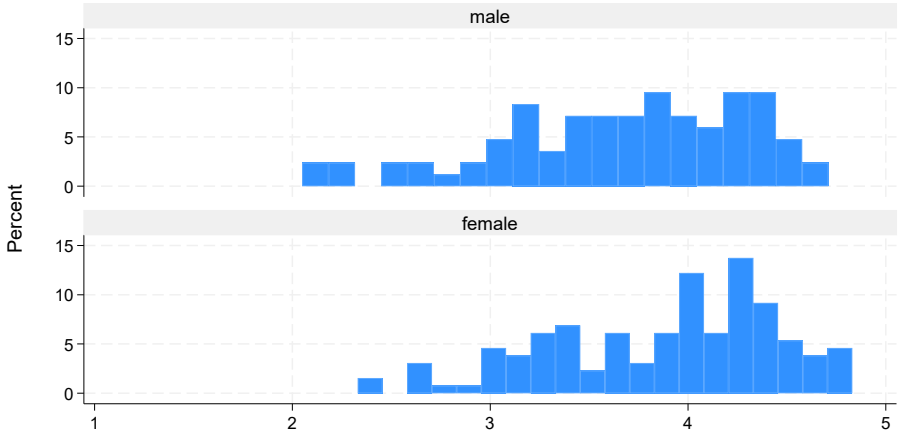
classmate video ratings, by target's gender



2024 MBAs. n=84 & 131, respectively.

Average Warmth Rating

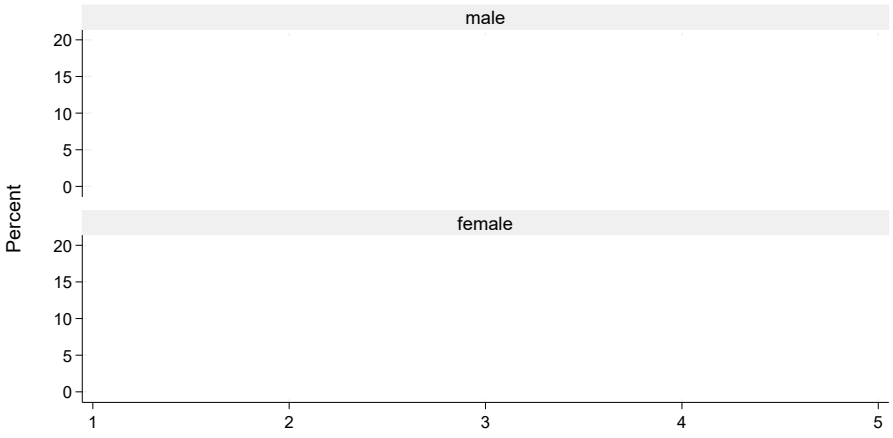
classmate video ratings, by target's gender



2024 MBAs. n=84 & 131, respectively. Means are 3.66 & 3.87.

Average Competence Rating

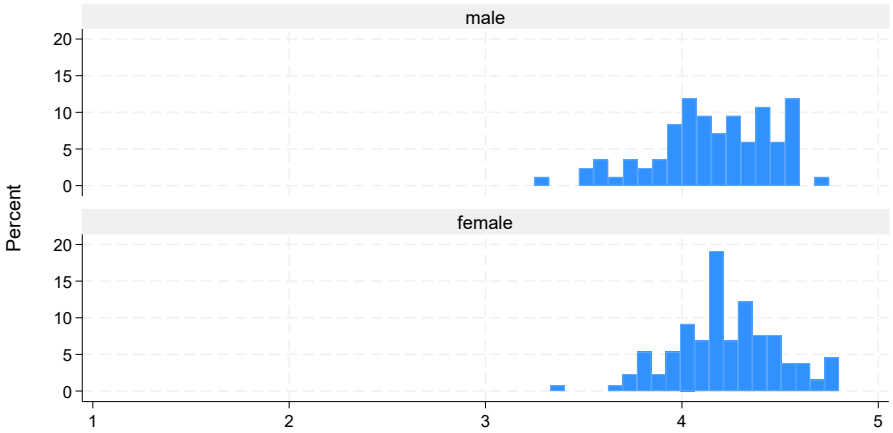
classmate video ratings, by target's gender



2024 MBAs. n=84 & 131, respectively. I

Average Competence Rating

classmate video ratings, by target's gender



2024 MBAs. n=84 & 131, respectively. Means are 4.16 & 4.23.

Some (random) reactions to evaluating peer videos (2025)

Smiles go a long way, they instantly create warmth and trust. Short sentences convey clarity and confidence. People form both positive and negative impressions quickly, often based on just a few words. Speaking with lots of words can make you seem more approachable and kind, but it may also make you appear less decisive or competent. The balance between warmth and expressing competence is my personal challenge.
I liked it when people had personal and professional details connected in the video. Having a personal touch created warmth in the introduction and led me to be more interested in what's coming after. On the flipside, I found myself very judgmental about the stories, especially whether they felt genuine or artificially crafted to convey a message/detail and create a certain impression, impacting the ratings I gave.
I noticed that I reacted negatively in my ratings to reading off a script, using buzzwords, and focusing on minutia vs. impact. I noticed I favored more genuine, off-the-cuff introductions that demonstrated high competency by distilling the work they did into easily digestible and concise experiences / outcomes while injecting humanity into their background and decision-making process.
I noticed that the most engaging introductions were clear, confident, and had a personal touch that made them memorable
Everyone had a unique style and I felt that the more memorable and easier to follow introductions were less of a resume walk-through or script and more of a life story. When certain people just read the bullet points on the resume, I tuned out. However, when students had a more friendly/ conversational tone, I paid attention and remembered them. This familiarity with their own story and presenting made me perceive them as more confident, competent, and warm.
I learned that being prepared and appearing genuine can often conflict. I looked for "human" traits more than I thought I would. I cared less about resume qualifications than insights into their principles and values. I also noticed that, as we discussed in class, presentation mattered more than content.

Where do you go from here?

1) Integrate it with your life experience

What resonates?

What's new or surprising?

What is your updated self-assessment?

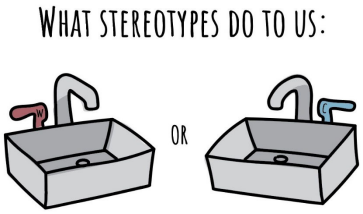
2) Decide what you want to work on

More/less warmth?

More/less competence?

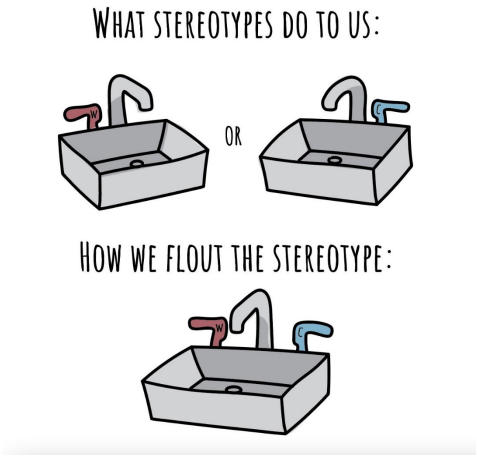
A specific speaking behavior?

Warmth & Competence



Stereotypes reduce our dimensionality

Warmth & Competence

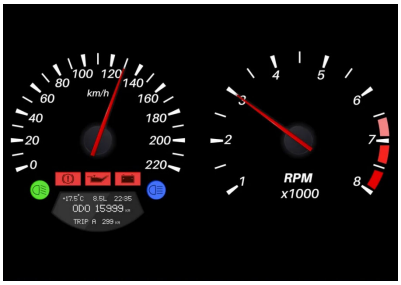


Stereotypes reduce our dimensionality

Simply showing both dimensions – even at different times - can be enough to fight the stereotype

3) To your persuasive efforts, bring…

Awareness **&** **Flexibility**





For more on this topic

Optional lunch session next **Wed Nov 19**

- McNulty led (Umi & Kathy)
- Focused on "leading across differences"
  - Insights and implications from the VITA and Leverage Inventory assessments
  - Interested in your reactions and take-aways for your leadership development
- Announcement and registration link this evening

Today's Agenda

Ethos

Video assessment / Warmth & Competence

Lipman videos

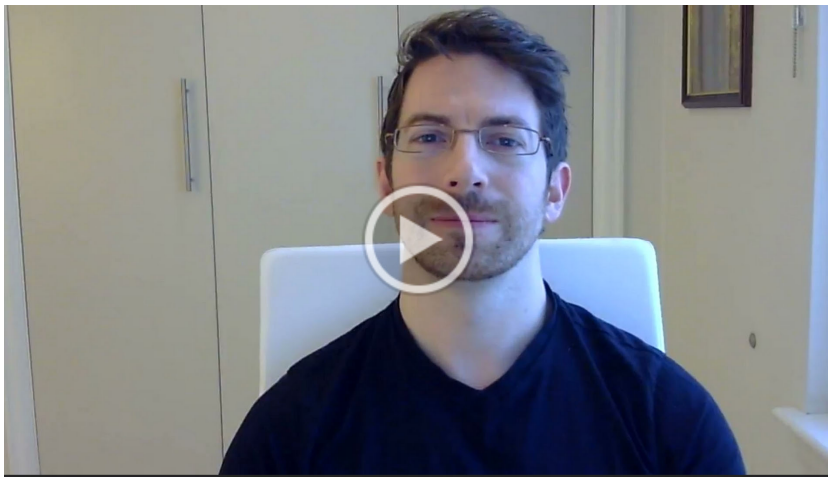
Lipman Videos

The 3-minute videos were submitted by 12 semi-finalists for the 2024 Lipman Family Prize. They were a small part of a substantial application process. They were competing for $500,000 in awards.

These four organizations were highly competitive (in fact three of them were the three finalists).

They were all given the same prompt: "What is unique about your organization?"

Simprints



Kakenya's Dream

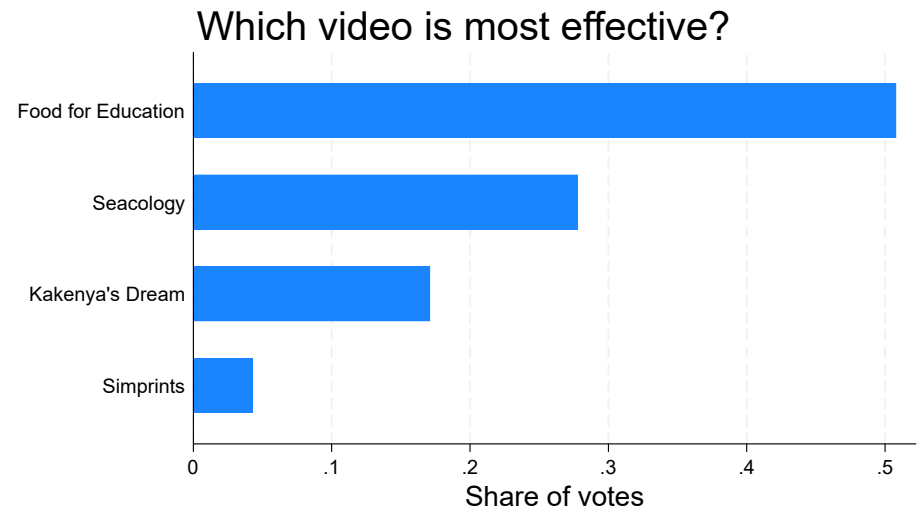


Seacology



Food For Education





Wharton MBAs, Fall 2025, n=187

What did you learn about yourself…?

I thought I was much more rational to make decisions, but, in fact, I am also really driven by emotions and intuition
Even if a topic is interesting (I'm a healthcare person), I still zone out if I'm not properly engaged.
I think I respond well to warmth and if it isn't there I need multiples more in seriousness and competence in order to compensate.
I am easily moved by stories and imagery
I am very heavily indexed on high production value.
I am pretty easily swayed by things that seem "appealing" - e.g., videos with high production value.
How much I disregard competence when the emotional quotient isn't filled first.
I need shiny things to keep my attention
I love a good story! Whether or not someone appears "genuine" greatly impacts my perception
I'm clearly biased towards a well-produced video!
I get repulsed by even the slightest perceived mis-alignments with my expectations... This is not good...
I definitely tend to use first impressions as a way to judge people
I'm way more influenced by non-verbal cues than I realized...My gut reaction happens fast and it's hard to overcome once it's set.
The first two seconds of a video callibrate how I choose to experience the rest of it.
That I hate how much I judge based on parameters I know I shouldn't judge.
i care about credibility and passion the most
My attention is really short and I am judgmental.

Concluding thoughts on persuasion

"Men judge generally more by the eye than by the hand"

- Our exercises suggest this line from The Prince is wiser than we'd like to admit.

"Image management" matters, and doesn't have to be misleading

- Worry about substance and symbolism (as we saw with de Mello)

Fundamental tension between polish and authenticity

- The best find ways to add human element to polished efforts

A couple of simple frameworks go a long way

- Questions to carry, ballast for our biases

As with networking, persuasion is most effective as a way of life

- What are your ethos/pathos/logos habits, your warmth/competence routines?

So inconvenient!

- But it wouldn't be a differentiating tactic otherwise